

Abstract art

Art of various cultures ranging from the Celtic to Islamic, has often featured abstract forms, but purely non-representational art did not emerge in the West until the 20th century. Several late-19th- and early-20th-century avant-garde artists emphasized colour, shape and visual sensations to impart emotions, but usually included some sort of representation.

From 1910-11, Kandinsky abstracted and distorted elements in his paintings, while simultaneously, Piet Mondrian (1872–1944) painted *The Grey Tree*, transforming a tree into abstract shapes and patterns. Meanwhile, in Stockholm in 1906, Hilma af Klint (1862–1944) created completely abstract paintings, combining shapes and dynamic brushstrokes in a series called *Primordial Chaos*. In 1912, Kandinsky published *On the Spiritual in Art*, arguing that colour and form can communicate without referencing the material world. By 1915-17, several more artists, including Malevich and Mondrian produced completely abstract art, and it became an important part of several later movements.



Mondrian, *The Grey Tree*, 1911